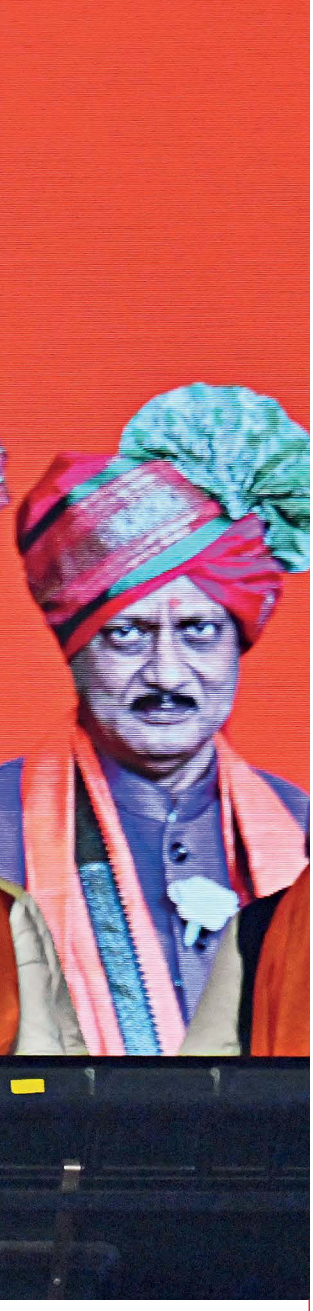


Photographs by MANDAR DEODHAR

TURNING THE TIDE Devendra Fadnavis takes oath as the new Maharashtra CM at Azad Maidan, Mumbai, Dec. 5

IN

June 2022, the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) sprang a surprise by choosing Shiv Sena rebel Eknath Shinde as the chief minister of Maharashtra, with their own Devendra Fadnavis, in whose cabinet the former was a minister from 2014-19, as his deputy. Though it was speculated that Fadnavis would be doing some backseat driving in the government, that was not to be. Shinde soon came into his own in terms of politics and policy, something that led to tensions within the ruling Mahayuti combine.

The wheel has now come full circle for both. Two and a half years ago, Fadnavis found himself having to propose Shinde's name for head of government. The Mahayuti's swashbuckling victory, with 230 of the 288 seats in the assembly amassed in its balance, could not go without credit being given to Shinde as its leader. But as a reward, he found himself cornered into having to return the favour to Fadnavis, nominating him for chief minister. Fadnavis will now rule Maharashtra for a third time. He has already set a few records of his own, being the first CM to complete a full five-year term (2014-19) after Vasantrao Naik (1967-72), also the one with the shortest tenure (five days in November 2019). But despite the BJP putting up its best-ever show in Maharashtra with 132 seats and all but obliterating the Opposition—none of the three parties in the rival Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) have enough numbers to even stake claim to the post of the leader of the Opposition—Fadnavis will be walking a tightrope on the political and administrative front.

The internal pulls and pressures ensured it took 11 days for the Mahayuti to stake claim to form the government after the November 23 results. Shinde, whose supporters ascribe the alliance's victory to his introduction of schemes like the Mukhyamantri Majhi Ladki Bahin Yojana (Rs 1,500 dole for women from poor families), was positioning himself for another shot at chief ministership. As a senior BJP leader noted, the Sena leader would have held the aces if the saffron party had secured less than 100 seats. However, its strong numbers and the support extended to Fadnavis by deputy CM Ajit Pawar and his Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), tipped the scales against Shinde.

After being sounded out about stepping back in favour of Fadnavis, Shinde is said to have dug his heels in and insisted on crucial portfolios like home. He also reportedly expressed his reservations on returning to the government as a deputy CM. Shinde's predicament is that his party is seen more as a loose conglomeration of legislators and local leaders who have coalesced around the authority that he wields, rather than an organisation per se. In what was seen as pressure tactics, his son Shrikant Shinde, a three-term Lok Sabha MP from Kalyan, tweeted on X (formerly Twitter) that the people of Maharashtra wanted to see his father as the CM, but deleted his post soon after.

The deadlock was broken after BJP state unit president Chandrashekhar Bavankule tweeted on November 30 that the new government would be sworn in on December 5 in Mumbai. Ironically, this was done even before the alliance formally met governor C.P. Radhakrishnan to stake claim to form the government. Shiv Sena leader and outgoing industries minister Uday Samant candidly admitted that they came to know about the swearing-in schedule after Bavankule's tweet.

Realising that the cards were stacked against him, Shinde fell in line. However, the BJP, too, faced a predicament. It has 132 MLAs in the 288-member House, plus the support of smaller parties and independents. Ditching Shinde and forming a government with the NCP would have served as affirmation that it follows a "use and throw" policy with regional allies. This led the party to "giving Shinde a long rope", according to a senior BJP legislator.

Ditching Shinde for a BJP-NCP regime would have affirmed the 'use and throw' charge against the saffron party

Shinde initially remained non-committal about joining the government, in a bid perhaps to wrangle a better deal for his Sena. He caved in just hours before the swearing-in on December 5, agreeing to take the oath of office as deputy CM. There are indications that Fadnavis may retain the crucial home portfolio, pacifying the Sena with urban development.